

❖ STUDY BEES ❖

POEM – THE EAGLE

by
Alfred, Lord Tennyson

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About the Poem

"The Eagle" (subtitled "A Fragment") is a short poem by Alfred, Lord Tennyson, first published in 1851. Composed of just two three-line stanzas, it is one of Tennyson's shortest works, yet it is famous for its powerful imagery and controlled, musical language. The poem captures a single moment: an eagle standing motionless on a high mountain crag, watching the sea far below, before suddenly diving down like a bolt of lightning.

Paraphrasing

Stanza 1:

*He clasps the crag with crooked hands;
Close to the sun in lonely lands,
Ring'd with the azure world, he stands.*

Paraphrasing:

The eagle grips the rocky crag tightly with its curved talons, described as "crooked hands." It stands alone in a remote, high place that seems close to the sun, completely surrounded by the blue sky – the "azure world" – emphasising both its height and its solitude.

Stanza 2:

*The wrinkled sea beneath him crawls;
He watches from his mountain walls,
And like a thunderbolt he falls.*

Paraphrasing:

Far below, the sea looks wrinkled and appears to move slowly, almost crawling, from the eagle's great height. The eagle watches everything from its high mountain perch, completely still and patient – until, without warning, it suddenly dives downward with the speed and force of a thunderbolt.

Rhyming Scheme

The poem is made up of two tercets (three-line stanzas), each following its own monorhyme scheme – AAA in the first stanza (*hands / lands / stands*) and BBB in the second (*crawls / walls / falls*). Written mainly in iambic tetrameter, this tight, complete rhyme within each stanza gives the poem a controlled, chant-like quality that suits its subject: calm, concentrated stillness followed by sudden, decisive action.

Theme

"The Eagle" celebrates the power, majesty, and solitude of nature. The eagle is presented as a solitary ruler of its high, remote world, calm and watchful until the decisive instant it chooses to act. The poem's brevity and controlled structure reflect this contrast between patient stillness and explosive power, offering a meditation on dominance, independence, and the awe-inspiring force of the natural world.

Figures of Speech

- **Personification**

The eagle's talons are called "crooked hands," and the sea is said to "crawl," giving both the bird and the landscape human or animal-like qualities.

- **Simile**

The eagle's sudden dive is compared directly to "a thunderbolt," emphasising its speed, power, and dramatic force.

- **Metaphor**

The sky is described as an "azure world," turning the vast expanse of blue sky into a whole world surrounding the solitary eagle.

- **Imagery**

Strong visual imagery – the "wrinkled sea," the "mountain walls," the eagle "close to the sun" – builds a vivid, elevated picture of the scene.

- **Alliteration**

Phrases such as "crag with crooked" use repeated consonant sounds to add rhythm and emphasis.

- **Contrast**

The poem contrasts the eagle's motionless watchfulness in the first stanza with its sudden, violent movement in the second, mirrored by the sharp, dramatic final line.

Questions & Answers

Q1. What does "crooked hands" refer to in the first line?

It refers to the eagle's curved talons, personified as hands gripping the rocky crag.

Q2. Where is the eagle standing, and how is its surroundings described?

It stands alone on a high mountain crag, in a remote place that seems close to the sun, completely encircled by the blue sky, or "azure world."

Q3. How is the sea described in the second stanza, and what device is used?

The sea is called "wrinkled" and said to "crawl" beneath the eagle – a personification that makes the vast sea seem small and slow-moving from the eagle's great height.

Q4. What happens in the poem's final line, and what device describes it?

The eagle suddenly dives down "like a thunderbolt," a simile that captures the speed, power, and drama of its fall.

Q5. How does the poem's structure reflect its meaning?

The poem shifts from calm, watchful stillness in the first stanza to sudden, forceful action in the second, mirroring the eagle's own patient watching followed by its explosive dive.

Q6. What is the central theme of the poem?

The poem celebrates the power, majesty, and solitude of nature, using the eagle as a symbol of quiet dominance followed by swift, decisive action.